break of the Second World War. Hansa Mehta had been put in place by Sardar Patel. She went about her task with great dedication, wisdom and boldness. My own father—who had gained a reputation as a mathematician for the work he had done at the Sorbonne—was appointed as the first professor and head of the mathematics department at Baroda University while still in his thirties. Nobel laureate Venkat Ramakrishnan, who obtained his first degree at Baroda, accords much credit to his mathematical training there for his work later.

Some of the learnings from the tenures of these three greats are worth bearing in mind as lessons for our policy makers. The first point is that they worked within the regulatory boundaries but with the freedom and boldness of vision that it permitted. The other point worth noting is that none of them were renowned academics. Gwyer did not have a PhD and Hansa Mehta may not even have had a masters degree. She had certainly not served in the capacity of a professional academic. Amarnath Jha was a professor but I am not sure if his standing as an academic in the world of English literature has had the impact that would compare with personalities like Meghnad Saha, Firaq Gorakhpuri or his own father, the great Sanskrit scholar Ganganath Jha. However, all three—Gwyer, Mehta and Jha—were matchless as vice-chancellors. We must note that by today's norms (those which have prevailed for many decades now), Gwyer and Mehta would not be considered eligible for the position of vice-chancellor. Perhaps our policy makers need to pay heed to some of these lessons embedded in the lives and actions of these individuals.

One other major learning that flows from the distinguished tenures of these three great vice-chancellors is that they served for fairly long periods of time; Gwyer for 12 years, Mehta for nine and Jha for 16. This ensured a continuity of high level vision for a sustained period. Unfortunately, most universities in India do not allow such freedom and even when they grant the possibility of a V-C serving a second term, the deserving ones do not seem to be considered.

Had Ramanujan come to me at the University of Delhi when I was V-C, I wouldn't have been able to enrol him. The regulations wouldn't have allowed me



NEW WAVE Students at Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), University of Delhi

HARDIK CHHABRA

But all things considered, we are making progress. One of the finest things to have happened to higher education in recent times is the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. Indian universities could not have asked for a more enlightened roadmap with clear and wise pathways. The challenge that faces us is to ensure its implementation does not get bogged down in unimaginative or counterproductive bureaucratic hurdles. We must grant a certain degree of freedom and space to institutions to attract eminent persons as V-Cs who shall then in turn attract and retain genuine academic talent from far and wide. Is that happening in any significant manner? I am afraid that, barring a few exceptions, the situation is disheartening.

The NEP has been hailed in many parts of the world, and has the potential to transform India into a knowledge economy. This is because it entails blending the curriculum around the needs and challenges of the nation and society. It prescribes that the pedagogy be based on solving problems through group-based project work. This also ensures a high degree of creative thinking, with various skills accruing to the learner largely through working on such projects. These are also required to be trans-disciplinary in nature, so that they help foster an entrepreneurial environment akin to what institutions like Stanford, Cambridge and almost every decent university fosters.

Lastly, I would like to draw attention to some of the good work happening in the universities and colleges of Jammu and Kashmir where I have the honour and pleasure of participating in the NEP's implementation. This is done in its true sense through activities like the much hailed new UG degree, christened 'Design Your Degree' formally, which embodies the true spirit of the NEP. ■

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